

ArcGIS StoryMaps: How People Move Through Them

A working comparison of every navigation format, with the trade-offs that actually matter.

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The Formats

FORMAT	HOW YOU MOVE	PROS	CONS
Story — scroll	Scroll down, top to bottom	Easy, familiar, holds a lot, works on phones	Endless scroll, no quick jump, content drifts off-center
Sidecar — Docked	Scroll. Map stays put, text scrolls beside it	Map holds still, room for real text	Still scrolling
Sidecar — Floating	Scroll. Full-screen media, text floats on top	Dramatic visuals	Scrolling, fits only short text
Sidecar — Slideshow	Click sideways	No scroll, swipe on tablet/phone, clean steps	Short text only per slide
Map Tour	Click point to point	Great for a list of places	Only works for location lists
Swipe	Drag a slider	Perfect for before/after, two maps	One trick only
Briefing	Click, arrow keys, or a clicker	Slide deck; jump anywhere via Table of Contents; present live; footers and branding	Separate build; feels like slides, not a flowing story
Collection	Pick from a menu of links	Bundles many maps and stories under one link	Not a story itself, just a wrapper

A Word on Scrollytelling

The scroll-everything default is the one everybody reaches for, and it's overused. The reader scrolls and scrolls and hopes the content stays centered, with no fast way to land on a single fact. I'm not a fan — and neither is the data-visualization crowd. Robert Kosara famously called it *the scrollytelling scourge* and pushed a click-through stepper instead.

It also has real accessibility holes that matter for federal-facing work: parts of the interactive maps can't be reached by keyboard or screen reader, so those users miss content entirely. The fix is to also supply the map data as a plain table.

The rule of thumb: scroll is for a genuine linear story you want people walked through start to finish. For anything reference or self-service, a click format — a Briefing or a Slideshow sidecar — beats it. And if people just need to look one thing up, a dashboard or app is the better tool than a Story Map at all.